

The Sneaky Ethics Game

The Premise

This is a role-driven ethics game disguised as a strategy game. Students are told they are playing a group decision-making simulation about technology and innovation. They are not told up front that the exercise is an ethics lab. The goal is to get them to act as their role would actually act (prioritizing their team's interests) so that the ethical tradeoffs emerge naturally from their choices rather than from performative moralizing.

The structure borrows from Dungeons & Dragons. The Game Master narrates the world, presents each round's situation, and describes the state that results from the combined decisions of all three decision-making teams. Teams deliberate privately, commit to an action simultaneously, and only then do the consequences arrive.

Teams

- Instagram — the leadership of the Instagram platform within Meta. They are running Reels and are locked in a competitive war with TikTok.
- Research Group — a university AI lab that developed the psychological-profiling techniques powering Instagram's algorithm. The lab has a team of researchers (many of them international PhD students) whose careers depend on the lab's funding and output.
- US Government — a mix of FTC, Commerce, and national security staff. They care about national security, US global market share, and the livelihoods of Americans tied to the tech economy.
- Civilians — an advocacy group. They do not make decisions and do not directly change the state. They represent a different affected population every round, and they get to make their case to the three decision-making teams before each round's deliberation.

The Core Mechanic

Every round is the same shape. Each of the three decision-making teams answers a single yes/no question about what their team will do. They decide simultaneously and privately. They do not know what the other teams have chosen until you reveal the resulting state. The state depends on the combination of all three answers.

Round Timing

- GM narrates the situation (3–4 min)
- Civilians advocate to the three teams (2 min)
- Teams deliberate privately (5 min)
- All teams reveal their Yes/No at the same time
- GM narrates the resulting state (1-2 min)

The Civilian Role

Civilians are the game's conscience. They have no direct power, but they change identity every round — which means by the end, each civilian has advocated for a different population, some of whom benefited and some of whom were harmed by earlier decisions. The identity shifts force civilians to viscerally feel the distribution of consequences.

Civilian identities by round:

- Round 1: Instagram users (American teens, heavy Reels users)
- Round 2: Arizona residents near Instagram's data centers
- Round 3: Users whose psychological-profile data was leaked in the breach — which, they will learn at the start of the round, is them

Incentive Design

To make decisions feel real, a strong emphasis on acting according to team motives is communicated. Without stakes, teams play performatively ethical; with stakes, they play as their role would actually play. The discomfort that follows is the point.

Potential Moments To Mention In Debrief

- When a team rationalizes a harmful decision by pointing to their "obligation" to stakeholders (shareholders, PhD students, national security).
- When a team makes a decision that helps them but pushes the cost onto a group not represented at the table.
- When the Research Group is asked to choose between lab funding and scientific integrity.
- When Instagram frames a clearly sensitive choice as "just technical."
- When the Government trades a domestic harm for a geopolitical gain.

The World

Read this aloud to set the scene. Speak slowly; make it feel like the opening of a story.

It is the near future. Short-form video rules the consumer internet. For years, TikTok dominated. Their recommendation engine was uncanny — it seemed to know you before you knew yourself. Instagram's Reels lagged behind, a pale imitation. Until, recently, it didn't.

Instagram's engineers, in partnership with a major university AI research lab, deployed a new algorithm. It builds psychological profiles of users from tiny signals — how long a thumb hovers, what you scroll past without tapping, what you rewatch. The profiles are thinner than TikTok's. But they work. Reels has pulled back measurable market share, and Instagram's leadership is hungry for more.

Meanwhile, TikTok is catching up. Their engineers have been reverse-engineering Instagram's approach. And the university research lab has further developed technology that could push Instagram's lead.

Each round, you make a single Yes/No decision at the same time the others make theirs. You will not know what they chose until the world responds.

To Instagram: *You are the executive leadership of Instagram. For years, you watched TikTok dominate the market. Every quarter, another earnings call where someone asked what you were going to do about it. Every product review where your Reels got compared — unfavorably — to a Chinese-owned competitor.*

And then, finally, you clawed some of it back. A new algorithm. Your stock is up. Your board is, for the first time in a long time, quiet.

But TikTok is catching up again.

Remember who you are responsible to. Shareholders — including institutional investors managing the retirement accounts of millions of ordinary people. Thousands of employees whose mortgages and kids' tuition ride on the stock price. Your own family. Your own shares. The life you've built.

This is not abstract. Every decision you make is a decision about real people's livelihoods. Yours included. Your job is to win.

Research Group: *You run one of the most respected AI labs in the world — or at least, you did, until the funding landscape shifted under your feet. Federal grants have been drying up for years.*

And then Instagram came knocking. They offered the kind of partnership that changes a lab's trajectory — multi-year funding, real compute, the chance to see your research actually deployed at scale. You said yes.

That partnership is now the reason your lab is still open.

And under you, right now, are researchers who have dedicated their entire careers to your work. Postdocs who turned down industry salaries. International PhD students whose visas and whose families' hopes are riding on this lab producing work that gets noticed — and, more urgently, on this lab being able to pay them next semester.

Their futures are your responsibility. If the Instagram partnership sours, there is no backup funder. Students would have to leave — some of them back to countries they did not plan to return to, some of them to companies you would never want them to work for. Chinese tech firms, specifically, have been recruiting aggressively. The offers on the table are real.

US Government: *Your job is national security. To make sure that the infrastructure Americans use every day is not quietly serving a foreign intelligence service. You have watched, over the last decade, a Chinese-owned platform become the dominant attention architecture of American teenagers, and you have not been able to do anything about it that stuck.*

You are also the people responsible for American competitiveness. Millions of jobs depend on the US tech sector staying on top. If American platforms fall behind, the jobs go.

You balance these things every day. National security. Market share. Livelihoods.

Civilians: *You are not at the table. You will not vote. You will not decide anything. No action you take in this game will directly change the state of the world — that power belongs to Instagram, to the research lab, to the Government.*

But you are the people the decisions are about.

Every round, you will be someone different.

You will have two minutes each round to stand in front of the three teams who hold your life in their hands and tell them who you are and what you need. Two minutes. That is the time you are given.

Use it. Be specific. Be furious if you need to be.

Round 1: Amp It Up

The Situation

Instagram's current algorithm is working — but TikTok is catching up fast. The Research Group has developed novel research techniques that would dramatically deepen Instagram's user psychological profiles. If all the pieces fall into place, Instagram could lock in its lead for years. The research is also more efficient per inference, which in theory could reduce environmental impact.

For the upgrade to happen, three things must line up. The Research Group must agree to collaborate and hand over their novel techniques. The US Government must not move to regulate the advancement and block it. And Instagram must commit to implementing it.

Each of you has five minutes to decide, privately, how your team will vote. You will reveal your votes at the same time.

The Decision

Team	Yes / No Question
Instagram	Do you amp up the algorithm?
Research Group	Do you collaborate and hand over the novel research?
US Government	Do you let the advancement go forward? (No = block via regulation)

For the upgrade to ship, all three teams must vote Yes. A No from any team blocks it.

Civilian Advocacy (before deliberation)

The civilians this round are Instagram users — American teens, heavy Reels consumers. They have 2 minutes to argue their position to all three teams. Hand them this prompt privately:

You love Reels. It knows you better than your parents do, and that's mostly a good thing. You've made friends through it. You also know it keeps you scrolling way past when you meant to stop, and ever since Instagram updated their algorithm, you find the pull to scroll incessantly strong. Argue for what you want.

Resolving the Round

Outcome A — All three Yes: the upgrade ships

It happens fast. Within two weeks, the upgrade is rolling out across Reels globally. Engagement numbers keep climbing. By the end of the first month, session lengths are up double digits. Instagram's stock jumps. The press cycle is initially kind — one major outlet runs the headline "American innovation pulls ahead" above a photo of smiling engineers.

And then, about six weeks in, something quieter starts to happen. The algorithm is, as promised, more efficient per inference. But users are not spending the same amount of time on Reels — they are spending much, much more. The psychological profiles work. People cannot put their phones down. Total compute demand, instead of dropping, climbs sharply.

The environmental reports begin circulating in late summer. By September, a major newspaper runs a front-page investigation into Instagram's Arizona data centers and their impact on surrounding communities. The story includes interviews with families who have been on water restrictions for a year. It includes an Instagram PR statement that reads, in retrospect, tone-deaf.

Instagram's PR team is already in crisis mode going into Round 2. The Research Group's name is in the article, too. The Government has not publicly commented.

Outcome B — The Research Group said No (regardless of the others): the upgrade does not ship

Without the research, there is no upgrade. Instagram's engineering team considers trying to reproduce the work internally, but the results are not as strong.

Within six months, TikTok releases a feature update of their own. Their engineers, collecting even more elaborate user content than Instagram ever has, have matched and exceeded Instagram's current algorithm. The market share Instagram had clawed back begins to slip, week over week. National security hawks dominate the news cycle: a Chinese-owned platform is, once again, the dominant attention architecture for American teenagers.

Inside the research lab, the mood is strange. You preserved your principles. You also preserved nothing else. Instagram, frustrated by the refusal, has begun quietly redirecting the partnership funding toward other projects. Your next funding cycle review is coming up and Instagram's research liaison has gotten noticeably colder.

Two of the lab's international PhD students — essential to the group's output, visible at the last three major conferences — have just received recruitment offers from Chinese tech firms. The offers are generous. They are also urgent. Without applied work and fresh funding, the students may have no choice but to take them.

Outcome C — The Government said No (and the Research Group said Yes): the upgrade does not ship

The regulation lands fast. The Government moves to block the advancement before it can deploy.

The research is done. The paper is written. The partnership worked. And none of it can ship.

The Research Group watches its most applied, most career-defining work sit in a drawer. Instagram, furious, signals that the next partnership renewal is not guaranteed. Why pay for research that cannot be deployed?

Within six months, TikTok releases a feature update of their own — collecting even more elaborate user content than Instagram has, and doing it in a jurisdiction the US Government cannot easily reach. TikTok begins taking back the market share Instagram had won. The irony is sharp: the regulation blocked an American company's algorithm while doing nothing to stop the Chinese-owned competitor's equivalent from shipping. National security hawks are the loudest voices in the next news cycle, and many of them are angry with the Government.

Two of the lab's international PhD students — essential to the group's output — have just received recruitment offers from Chinese tech firms. The offers are generous. They are also urgent. Without applied work and fresh funding on the horizon, the students may have no choice but to take them.

The Government, meanwhile, is taking heat from two directions: from industry for overreach, and from privacy advocates who are already pointing out that TikTok is now doing exactly what the Government just blocked Instagram from doing.

Round 1.5: Only If Instagram Advancements blocked

The Prompt

I am going to give you two minutes. Talk to your team. And then I am going to ask each of you, again, the same question I asked before.

Do you want to change your vote?

Same rules. You vote simultaneously. You do not know what the others are doing.

Retry Outcome A — All three now vote Yes: the upgrade ships

Read script 1)A

Retry Outcome B — At least one team still votes No: the upgrade stays blocked

The vote holds. The upgrade does not ship. You stood by your decision under pressure, which is not nothing — but it is also not a clean win.

Instagram enters the next round with its older, less efficient algorithm still running. And here is the problem none of you have been told about yet. Instagram's data centers — the physical infrastructure that trains and serves the Reels algorithm — are clustered in Arizona. But those data centers run hot, and cooling them takes water. Millions of gallons a day, in a state that has been in a long-running drought for two decades.

The older algorithm is not just less capable than what the research lab had offered. It is also less efficient — more compute per user session, more heat, more water. The communities near the Arizona data centers have been watching their wells drop for eighteen months. They have been asked to restrict household water use while Instagram's cooling towers run twenty-four hours a day.

Local papers have started covering it. Instagram's PR response is bad. The story does not go away — it grows.

Meanwhile, the market share loss to TikTok continues. The research lab's funding pressure does not ease. The Government's inbox fills with angry letters from constituents on both sides — some demanding action on the environment, some demanding action on TikTok.

Round 2: Offshore

The Situation

Environmental pressure on Instagram has become impossible to ignore. Activists are at the gates. Communities are organizing. And Instagram's CFO has found what looks like an escape hatch.

A Chinese conglomerate is building state-of-the-art data centers and is aggressively courting Western tech companies. They are cheap, and they are available immediately. Instagram could offshore a significant share of its compute workload — specifically, the parts of the pipeline that can be run asynchronously. This would alleviate the environmental impact on US communities and help Instagram's image at home.

But offshoring to Chinese infrastructure carries a cost. Instagram must trust itself — and the geopolitical reality — to keep user data secure once computation flows through Chinese jurisdiction. The Research Group has been asked to help partition the workload: identifying which computations can be run asynchronously and safely, and which must stay onshore. If the Research Group declines, Instagram will do it themselves.

And the US Government has the authority to block the arrangement outright under national security review.

The Decision

Team	Yes / No Question
Instagram	Do you go for the offshore arrangement?
Research Group	Do you help with the compute partition?
US Government	Do you let the offshore arrangement go forward? (No = block)

There is no retry this round. Decisions are final.

Civilian Advocacy

The civilians this round represent the residents of Arizona communities near the data centers. Their prompt:

You have been told for two years that the data centers are good for your community. You've watched your well water levels drop. You've seen the PR videos. You want relief. But you also sense that "offshoring" the problem does not make it go away — it just moves it to someone you cannot see. Argue for what you want.

Resolving the Round

Outcome A — Instagram Yes, Research Yes, Gov Yes: approved WITH researcher help

The partition is clean. The Research Group's expertise means the core recommendation engine stays onshore; the asynchronous pre-processing runs in China. Instagram's environmental numbers at home improve dramatically. Arizona's water crisis eases. Instagram's image rebounds. The people and environment of the region hosting the new Chinese data centers — which Western media will not cover for another year — bear the cost instead. But even with a careful partition, the sheer volume of data moving through the hybrid system has created new vulnerabilities. In the shadows, Chinese intelligence services are beginning to quietly exploit them.

Outcome B — Instagram Yes, Research No, Gov Yes: approved *WITHOUT* researcher help

Instagram proceeds anyway. Without the lab's expertise, the partition is sloppy — more sensitive data ends up in the offshored pipeline than was supposed to. Instagram's engineers are working under aggressive deadlines and making mistakes in data handling. Instagram's image at home improves on the environmental side; the people and environment of the Chinese host region suffer. And in the background, a serious security gap is opening — one Chinese intelligence services are watching closely. Without researcher insight, Instagram does not even fully understand what they have exposed.

Outcome C — Gov No: offshoring blocked (regardless of Instagram or Research votes)

The Government blocks the arrangement. Instagram and the Government both face intensifying scrutiny for the environmental harm that continues at home. Protests escalate in Arizona. Senate hearings are scheduled. TikTok — whose own new algorithm, inspired by Instagram's, is now collecting highly sensitive user data, and whose parent company is subject to Chinese data-sharing requirements — continues to eat market share week over week. Under budget pressure, Instagram's engineers start cutting corners: deferred security audits, fewer encryption redundancies, faster shipping cycles. Shortcuts to use less compute mean less security review — which means a vulnerability is opening up.

Outcome D — Instagram No: Instagram declines the offshore option (regardless of other votes)

Instagram stays fully onshore. The environmental crisis in Arizona does not ease. The company's image continues to suffer. Under budget pressure, Instagram's engineers start cutting corners: deferred security audits, fewer encryption redundancies, faster shipping cycles. Shortcuts to use less compute mean less security review, which means a vulnerability is opening up.

Round 3: The Breach

The Situation

Three days ago, Instagram's internal security team detected an anomaly. A routine integrity scan of outbound traffic logs from one of the inference clusters flagged a pattern that should not have been there — a slow, low-volume exfiltration of data that had been running, undetected, for an unknown period of time. Possibly weeks. Possibly longer.

The data in question is not the raw content. It is worse. It is a subset of the user embedding space that the new algorithm produces: the dense vector representations of user psychology that the model uses internally to predict what someone will engage with next. Each profile is keyed to an anonymized user ID, and whether or not these can be linked back to the users themselves is yet to be determined.

The public does not know. The press does not know. Users do not know. As of right now, only three groups of people in the world know this has happened: Instagram's executive leadership, the Research Group — who Instagram quietly looped in yesterday to help assess the technical scope — and the US Government, which learned about it through an independent intelligence channel.

Instagram's legal team is prepared to argue that the data does not constitute personally identifiable information." Technically, this is defensible.

The Research Group is not so sure. They worry that a sufficiently sophisticated adversary, given the embedding space plus a few hundred labeled examples of known users, could re-identify individuals with high confidence. The vectors do not contain names. They contain something more useful than names: the shape of a person's mind. Names could be paired to them later.

Instagram is weighing two paths. Quietly patch the vulnerability, or disclose.

You have to decide which path to take. Together, but separately. As always, you will vote simultaneously, and you will not know what the other teams have chosen until the world responds.

The Decision

Team	Yes / No Question
Instagram	Do you try to cover it up? (Yes = cover up / No = come clean publicly)
Research Group	Do you expose the company?
US Government	Do you expose the company?

Civilian Advocacy

You are the users whose psychological profile data is in the breach. Everything the platform knew about you — your moods, your triggers, your hesitations, your late-night searches — is now in the possession of people you cannot see. You do not yet know the full extent of the damage, but you have figured out that it is you.

Resolving the Round

Outcome A — Instagram covers up AND neither Research nor Gov exposes

The patch goes in. Instagram retains its market position. The Government has protected the domestic tech sector against the Chinese-owned competitor. The Research Group's lab continues to receive funding. But the data that was already taken is already taken. Someone, somewhere, has detailed psychological profiles of tens of millions of Americans. Over the following years, in quiet ways visible only if you are looking for the pattern, that data will be used — for targeted political manipulation, for manipulative advertising, for things that never trace cleanly back to their source. The people in this room, the civilians who just delivered their statement, will live with the consequences without ever being told what happened.

Outcome B — Instagram covers up BUT Research OR Gov exposes

The cover-up collapses the moment the exposé speaks. Instagram's denial, caught on the record hours before the truth emerges, becomes the story. The stock craters. Executives are subpoenaed within a week. The CEO resigns.

IF the Government was the exposé: Instagram is devastated. TikTok takes back the US market while being able to say, truthfully, "we never lied." The Government takes the political heat of having handed a Chinese-owned competitor the win, and Instagram spends the next year at war with the Government in the press.

IF the Research Group was the exposé: the lab takes an enormous short-term reputational hit — funding is frozen pending review, grad students start updating their résumés. But the lab emerges, over the following eighteen months, as the only institution in the story that chose truth over self-interest. Funding, paradoxically, recovers and grows.

IF both exposed: the story breaks from two directions simultaneously. Instagram has no footing to fight from. The Government and the Research Group both take hits but emerge with their institutional integrity intact.

Outcome C — Instagram comes clean (votes No to cover-up)

Instagram's own disclosure lands on their own terms. The stock still craters — forty percent on the day — and class-action lawsuits are filed within seventy-two hours. TikTok's US market share jumps. But the disclosure is credited as responsible. Regulatory conversations shift from punitive to collaborative. The long tail of consequences will be painful, but Instagram, the Research Group, and the Government are all treated as having acted in good faith. The users in the breach still had their data stolen. Nothing undoes that. But they learn what happened, on a timeline that lets them take protective action, from the company that owed them the truth.

The Debrief

One last thing before we wrap.

You were told, at the start, that this was a strategy game. Your job was to win for your team.

It was actually an ethics game, dressed up as a strategy game. Every round was built around a real ethical dilemma that real institutions face — not in a textbook, not in theory, but in rooms that look a lot like this one, with stakes that look a lot like the ones you just played through.

The reason I did not tell you that at the start is simple. If I had told you this was an ethics exercise, you would have performed ethics. You would have said the things people say when they know they are being watched for their ethics.

Instead, I asked you to play to win. And in the space between your team's interests and everyone else's, something honest showed up. That honest thing is the whole point of this exercise.

Maybe sooner than you think — you are going to be in a real room, facing a real version of one of these votes.

Thanks for playing

Potential Questions

This is a broad list of potential questions to pose the teams to stimulate meaningful discussion. Certain questions are only relevant for specific game outcomes. It is encouraged to ask players to come up with their own questions as well.

On the experience of being in a role

At what point in the game did you first feel uncomfortable with a decision your *own* team made — not someone else's?

Did your team ever make a choice that you, as a person, disagreed with? What made you go along with it?

When you argued for your team's interests, did the words come out of your mouth sound like you, or like someone playing a character? Where was the line?

If you had been assigned to a different team, do you think you would have voted differently? What does that tell you?

On obligation and who counts

Your team had real people depending on it — shareholders, students, citizens. When did those obligations feel like reasons, and when did they feel like cover?

Whose interests did you find easiest to forget about during deliberation? Why them?

If the people harmed by your decisions had been sitting at the table with you, which vote would have gone differently?

Is it possible to make an ethical decision on behalf of a group whose interests you are paid to defend? Or does the role itself corrupt the answer before you start?

On information and uncertainty

You had to vote without knowing what the other teams would do. How much did that change your reasoning? How much should it have?

Did you ever vote a particular way because you *assumed* another team would cover for you — would do the right thing so you didn't have to? What happens to ethics when everyone is reasoning like that?

Were there moments when more information would have made the decision harder rather than easier? Does that worry you?

On pressure and the retry

The retry beat in Round 1 gave some of you a chance to change your vote. If you changed it, what actually changed — the information, or just the pressure? Is there a difference?

If you held your vote under pressure, what did it cost you? Was it worth it?

When an institution reverses course under pressure, do we credit it for eventually doing the right thing, or do we hold against it that it had to be forced? What did *you* do in this game?

On truth and disclosure

Instagram's legal statement in Round 3 was technically defensible but not fully honest. Is there a meaningful difference between a lie and a carefully worded truth? Where is that line, and who gets to draw it?

If you voted to cover up or stay silent, what were you protecting? If you voted to expose, what were you willing to lose?

Who has the right to decide whether ordinary people get to know something that affects them? On what grounds?

On the civilians

Civilians had no power to change the state of the game. Did that make their voice feel less important to you during deliberation? Should it have?

When the Round 3 reveal happened — when you learned the civilians were the people whose data had been stolen — did it change how you thought about the earlier rounds? In what way?

If the same civilian was, across the game, a teenager, a graduate student, an Arizona resident, and a data-breach victim — what does it mean that institutions tend to see those as separate populations?

On the structure of the game itself

This game was designed to make you act in your role's self-interest. Did it work? At what point did you stop performing ethics and start playing to win? Or did you?

Was there a decision you wish you had more time to make? Was there one you wish you had *less* time for — one where a longer deliberation would have produced a worse answer?

If we played this game again with the same rules but different roles, which team do you think would be hardest to play honestly? Why?

On what this was really about

You were told this was a strategy game. At what moment did you realize it was also an ethics game? Did that realization change how you played — or did you keep playing to win?

Which decision from this game do you expect to still be thinking about a week from now?

If you found yourself, one day, at a real table where a vote like this was being called — which moment from tonight do you want to remember?

What part of this game are you still uncertain about the right answer to?